has been a key political pillar in the Greater Hyderabad area ever since.[37] Yet, until the ascent of Asaduddin Owaisi, it had remained a local Hyderabad player.

When we met, AIMIM had seven MLAs in Telangana's 119-member state assembly and had already started making moves in national politics as a 'Muslim' party out to represent constituencies with large Muslim populations. It had already registered a noticeable presence in some municipal polls in Muslim-significant areas in Maharashtra (Nanded-Waghela city), Karnataka and UP. By 2020, it had garnered for itself one Lok Sabha MP (Aurangabad) and two MLAs in Maharashtra, two more Members of Legislative Council (MLCs) in Telangana and, importantly, five MLAs in Bihar's 2020 assembly poll.

Not surprisingly, AIMIM's rise in each of these places had been at the expense of the Congress, which had benefitted from minority vote-bank politics in the past. Consequently, Owaisi has often been accused by Congress leaders of 'being a partner with the majoritarian right-wing radicalisation' in a mutual game of political extremes on the Muslim question.[38] Owaisi, who has always scoffed at these charges of being the BJP's 'B-team', met us in his anteroom wearing his trademark pin-striped sherwani and skullcap. As we interviewed him for our election show, surrounded by framed verses from the Koran on the walls, I asked him about the Congress's charge that his party, by splitting the anti-BJP vote, in effect ended up helping the BJP. 'This is clear frustration on their [Congress's] part,' he responded indignantly, arguing that he was being blamed for the Congress's own failures. 'They don't want to do serious introspection. For example, I didn't contest in Delhi, Haryana, J&K or Jharkhand elections. I can go on and on, but you [Congress] still don't win. In Hyderabad municipal elections, of 150 municipal corporators, how many does Congress Party have?'[39] It was a fair point. Owaisi then went on to explain why he felt Muslims needed new representation, arguing that parties they had voted for before had failed. Ergo, the need for a 'Muslim' political party. As he put it:[40]